Chapter 1 / Ruby Orchard - original 3D fantasy art direction



Design authority: what is locked and what still needs approval

LOCKED FROM EXPANDED DEVELOPMENT BIBLE

- Heroes are rounded, childlike, 2.7-3.2 heads tall; same gameplay ability and scale.
- Pip is a floating magical PAINTBRUSH. Ruby is a friendly, rescued dragon.
- Before the rescue, environmental pigments stay beautifully grayscale.
- After the rescue, eligible RED objects return; other colors remain story-locked.
- No pay-to-win; no harming Guardians; creator approval before asset production.

WHAT THESE GENERATED BOARDS DO NOT MEAN

The overview renders are mood boards, NOT final 3D models. Some show colorful props too early and one incorrectly depicts Pip as a dragon. Reject those discrepancies. Do not ask Claude to model from inaccurate labels or ship cropped PNGs as game geometry.

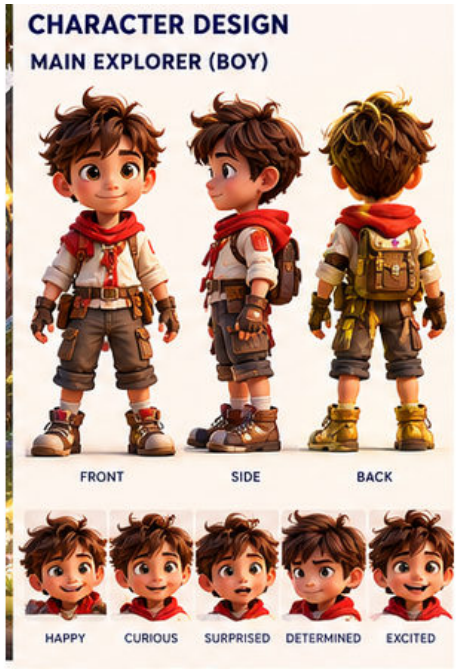
We approve core characters and one consistent grayscale-to-red environment first;
afterward, create front/side/back/3-4 model sheets, scale tests, rigging, material stages,
GLB exports and in-engine gameplay tests.

Boy Explorer / character exploration



Curious, kind, confident young adventurer.

Soft cheeks; practical jacket/hoodie; chunky shoes; desaturated clothing; small red sash only after Ruby.



Required final approval views

Front, side, back, 3/4, five expressions, same-lens pair comparison, gameplay camera, grayscale silhouette, animation test.

Girl Explorer / character exploration



Equally capable hero with matching visual weight and game scale.

Round youthful proportions; comfortable overalls or jacket; curls/braid; sturdy footwear; same Wonderbrush hold.



Required final approval views

Front, side, back, 3/4, five expressions, same-lens pair comparison, gameplay camera, grayscale silhouette, animation test.

Pip / floating magical paintbrush companion



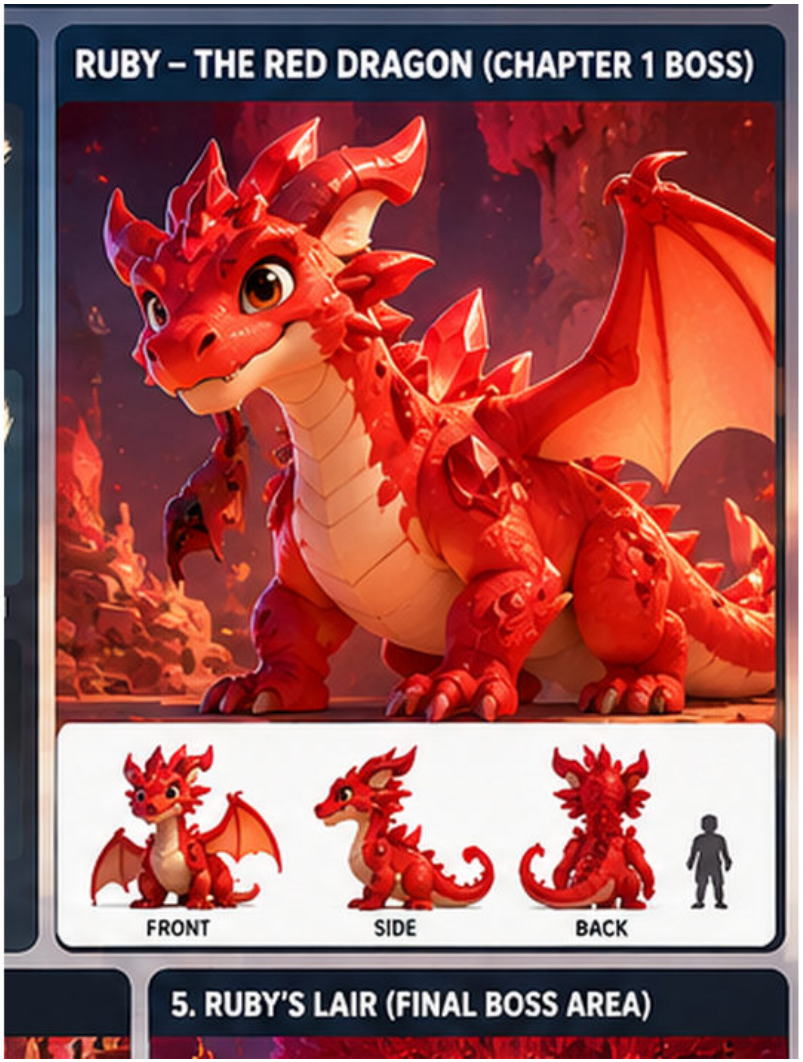
Design requirements

A small floating brush with warm wooden handle, soft bristles, expressive eyes, and gentle hover animation; approximately 35% Explorer height.

Five expressions: intrigued, concerned, excited, pointing and relieved. Never cover the player during jumps or mirror puzzles.

NO wings, dragon tail or horns. An overview image incorrectly labeled Pip as a dragon: that interpretation is rejected.

Ruby / corrupted-to-restored dragon



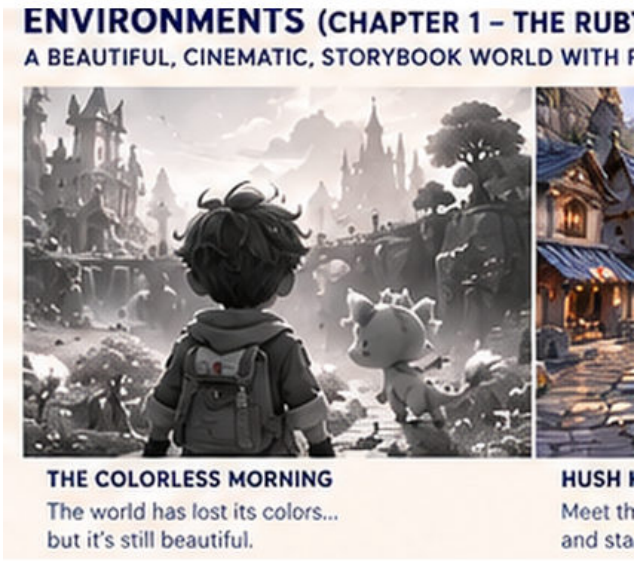
The heart of Chapter 1

Friendly bean-shaped plush dragon, thick rounded muzzle, giant kind eyes, short horn buds, rounded claws and broad soft wings. Ruby is large compared with the child, never frightening.

Corrupted: gray-lilac and worried, with three spell crystals suspended AWAY from the body. Restored: berry-red scales and coral wing underside on the SAME mesh.

No attack on Ruby. The player frees external crystals through environmental puzzles. Ruby thanks the child; Flame Burst unlocks afterward (proposed change).

Chapter 1 locations / grayscale beginning



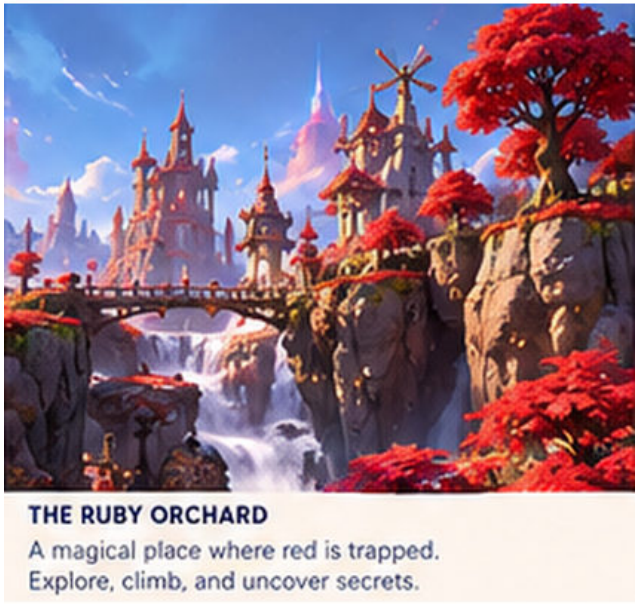
Bedroom

Artwork proposal; needs in-engine test



Hush Hollow

Artwork proposal; needs in-engine test



Orchard: restored mood

Artwork proposal; needs in-engine test

Important: These are not same-camera, color-locked game screenshots. Develop the opening as beautifully textured gray. The colorful orchard image illustrates the emotional payoff only; it is NOT permitted as the pre-Ruby gameplay environment.

The core magic / red restoration - do NOT recolor the whole world

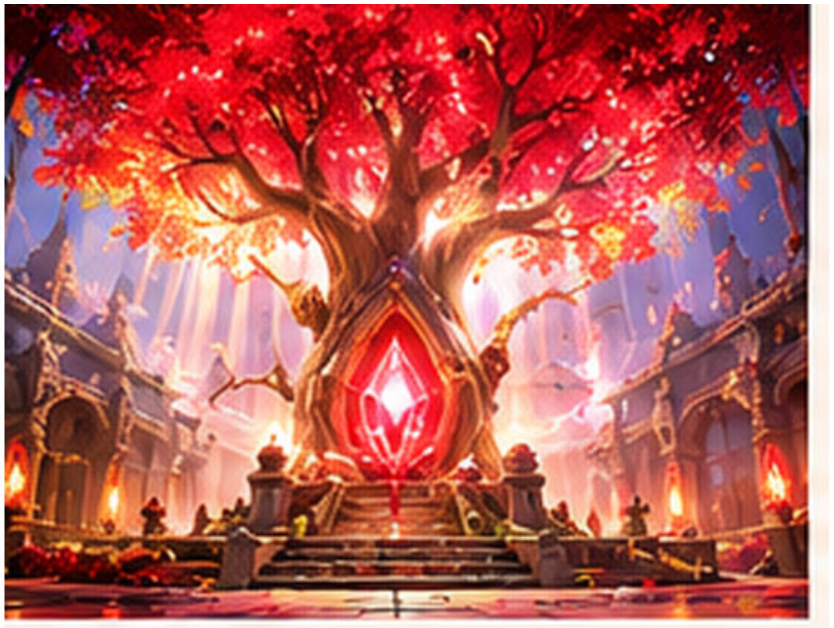


Mechanics: red-capable meshes have two authored material states; a controlled camera pass shows the red wave travel from crystal, to berry trees and select roofs, to the hero sash. Ruby turns red on the same rig. Sky, grass and locked blue/yellow/green objects stay gray.

Jam-Jar Jester + Ruby Sanctuary / play-space references



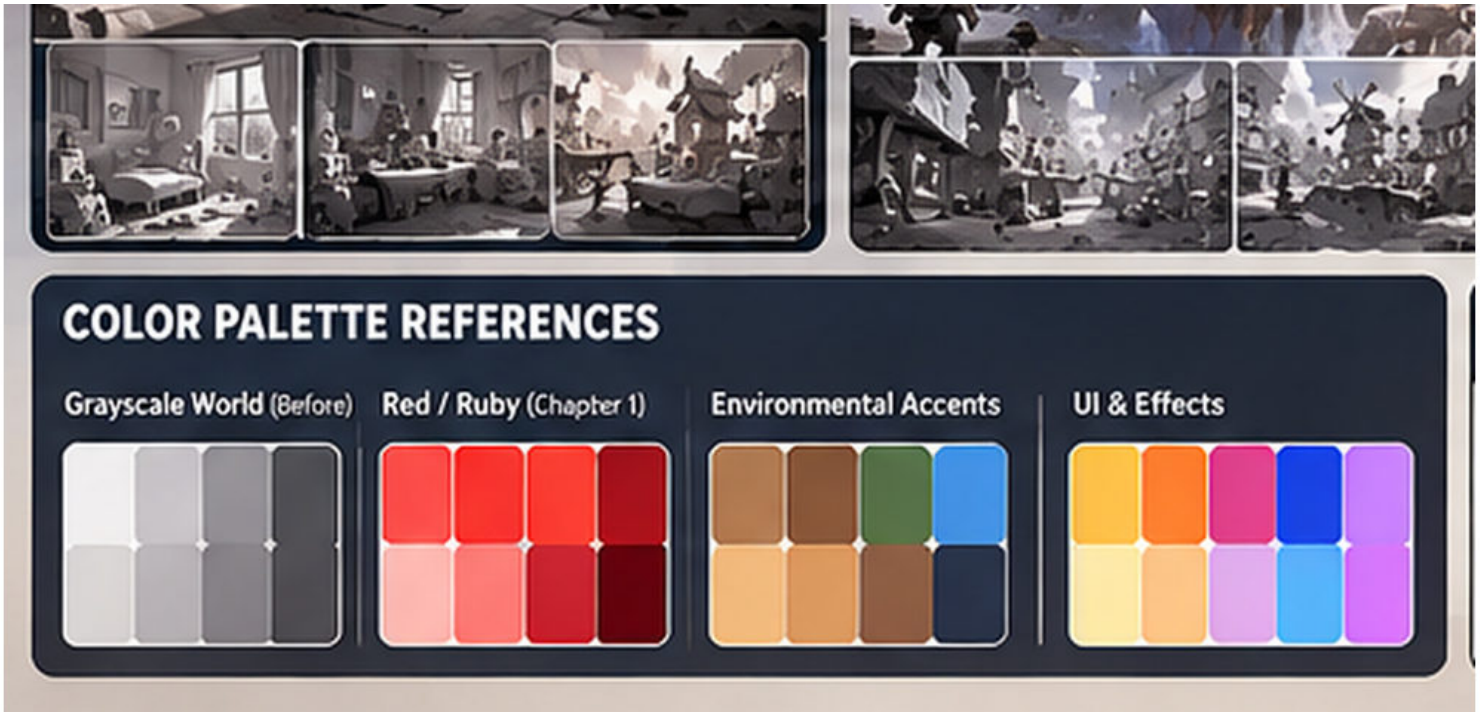
Jester: a funny jar, not a villain to injure



Sanctuary: safe circular boss arena

Ruby has THREE phases: rolling fruit + crystal, rotating mirrors WHILE berries continue, then timed safe movement around three stomp waves. Use clear symbols and non-color-only telegraphs.

Palette hierarchy + staged material approvals



Canonical technical swatches are documented in the workbook: Sky #CAD0D5 | Stone #ADB4B9 | Bark #766F70 | Berry Red #D64F59 | Restoration #EF4444 | Ruby scales #D94A59 | Coral underside #F48A7A.

Swatches inside generated images are illustrative only. Test lighting and material colors on actual in-engine surfaces before approving.

Review and approval checklist

- [ ] Approve shared childlike silhouette and boy/girl height, body scale and rig choice.
- [ ] Reject saturated red scarves/clothes before Ruby; model grayscale outfits with unlockable red sash.
- [ ] Approve Pip as a floating animated brush, NOT a pet dragon.
- [ ] Approve Ruby as a large, kind plush-shaped dragon in both gray-lilac and berry-red states.
- [ ] Approve grayscale bedroom / Hush Hollow / orchard look and architecture family.
- [ ] Approve exact same-camera Ruby Orchard before/after concept (still to be made).
- [ ] Create game-scale screenshots and 4-angle turntables; assess at low performance settings.
- [ ] Begin modular 3D modeling only after the preceding image/scale approvals.

All images are proposals. Keep original Blender/GLB/texture sources separate from approval PNGs.